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OUR WHOLE COUNTRY:

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OR THE

PAST AND PRESENT

U.S.

B.

OF THE

UNITED STATES,

HISTORICAL AND DESCRIPTIVE.

IN TWO VOLUMES,

CONTAINING THE

GENERAL AND LOCAL HISTORIES AND DESCRIPTIONS OF EACH OF THE STATES, TERRITORIES, CITIES, AND TOWNS OF THE UNION; ALSO, BIOGRAPHICAL SKETCHES OF DISTINGUISHED PERSONS, TOGETHER WITH A LARGE AND VARIED COLLECTION OF INTERESTING AND VALUABLE INFORMATION FOR ALL CLASSES, RELATING TO EVERY PART OF OUR COUNTRY FROM THE ATLANTIC TO THE PACIFIC.

ILLUSTRATED BY SIX HUNDRED ENGRAVINGS;

PRESENTING VIEWS OF ALL THE CITIES AND PRINCIPAL TOWNS—PUBLIC BUILDINGS—BIRTHPLACES AND SEATS OF EMINENT AMERICANS—PUBLIC MONUMENTS AND THOSE OF THE ILLUSTRIOUS DEAD—BATTLE-FIELDS—HISTORICAL LOCALITIES—RELICS OF ANTIQUITY—NATURAL CURIOSITIES, ETC., ALMOST WHOLLY FROM DRAWINGS TAKEN ON THE SPOT BY THE AUTHORS, THE ENTIRE WORK BEING ON THEIR PART THE RESULT OF OVER

16,000 MILES OF TRAVEL AND FOUR YEARS OF LABOR.

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VOLUME II.

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private, comparing well with any city in this country or any other. The shore of the lake and northern parts of the city, are occupied with the finest of residences. Some of the most remarkable public buildings are, the Court House, the Merchants Exchange, the Marine Hospital, the Medical College, the Second Presbyterian Church, etc. Burch's and Wadsworth's blocks, on Lake-street, are rows of iron front stores, that, in extent and beauty, have no equal in any business houses in any city of Europe.

A very elegant building material has recently been brought into use. It is found in great abundance about 20 miles from the city, on the line of the Illinois canal. "It is a compact lime-stone, of a pale yellow shade, somewhat lighter than the celebrated Caen stone of France, now so fashionable in New York. The grain is so fine that the fracture, or cut surface, resembles that of chalk in texture. It is durable, is easily wrought, and the color is peculiarly pleasing and grateful to the eye. There is another stone of similar texture, of the color of freshly fractured slate, or of the mark made on a slate by a pencil; but it is not so beautiful as the kind before mentioned. It soils readily, and has, at a short distance, the effect of a dirty white. There are also other architectural stones in considerable abundance and variety; but none of great beauty or importance have come under our observation. The Presbyterian Church on Wabash Avenue, is built of a blue, bituminous lime-stone, the pitchy matter of which has exuded and run down the sides, giving the building the appearance of having a partial coat of tar. The general impression it produces, is that of great antiquity; and if this idea could be preserved and harmonized by the early pointed gothic, and a good growth of ivy, the effect would be very fine."

Until 1856, most of the streets of Chicago were planked, and the buildings then erected were generally without cellars. As a consequence, in the spring of the year, the ground asserted its original character of swamp. The planks actually floated, and as the heavy wagons passed along, the muddy water gushed out on every side. Since 1856, such a grade has been established, that when finished, will raise the entire city from two to five feet.

"There is, with almost every block of buildings, a change of grade, sometimes of one foot, sometimes of three feet, sometimes of five. These ascents or descents are made by steps, or by short, steep, inclined planes of boards, with or without cleats or cross pieces, to prevent slipping, according to the fancy of the adjoining proprietor who erects them. The profile of a Chicago sidewalk would resemble the profile of the Erie canal, where the locks are most plenty. It is one continual succession of ups and downs. The reason of this diversity is, that it was found necessary, at an early period in the history of the place, to raise the grade of the streets. It was afterward found necessary to raise the grade still higher, and again still higher—as each building is erected, its foundation and the sidewalk adjoining have been made to correspond to the grade then last established, and so it will not happen until the city is entirely rebuilt, that the proper grade will be uniformly attained. In the mean time, the present state of things will repress undue curiosity in the streets, and keep fire-engines off the sidewalks, which is a great point gained."

The process of *raising* of the houses and stores, in Chicago, is one of great interest, literally, a method of digging a great city out of the mud. "Buildings of brick or stone, 150 feet by 200, and five stories high, are raised up several feet by a system of screws, without a crack or the displacement of a single thing. A hotel contracts to be lifted up. In a short time 2,000

screws are under it, and little by little the house rises. Nothing is changed within. The kitchen cooks, the dinning-room eats, the bar drinks, and all the rooms smoke, as if nothing was going on! A block of stores and offices



Raising a Block of Buildings in Chicago.

The view is engraved from a photograph taken for this work, in April 1860, of a street scene in Chicago. The entire block on the north side of Lake-street, extending from Clark to La Salle-street, having a front of 320 feet—is shown in the process of being raised up four feet and two thirds, by 6,000 screws placed under it; turned, at signals, by a force of 600 men. Most of the stores are 180 feet deep, and five days were consumed in the task.

begins this new process of growth, and all the tenants maintain their usual functions; and, except the outrageous heaps of dirt and piles of lumber, everything goes on as before. The plank into the door gets a little steeper every day. But goods come in and go out, and customers haunt the usual places."

The most remarkable feat of the kind occurred in Chicago, in the spring of 1860, when an immense block was raised. This is shown in our engraving, and thus described in the Chicago Press and Tribune of the time, under the caption of "*The Great Building Raising.*"

For the past week the marvel and the wonder of our citizens and visitors has been the spectacle of a solid front of first-class business blocks, comprising the entire block on the north side of Lake-street, between Clark and La Salle-streets, a length of 320 feet, being raised about four feet by the almost resistless lifting force of 6,000 screws.

The block comprises 13 first class stores, and a large double marble structure, the Marine Bank Building. Its subdivisions are a five-story marble front block

of three stores; a second four-story block of three stores, and a five-story block of four stores, at the corner of Clark-street—these all presenting an unbroken front, in the heart of our city, and filled with occupants.

This absence from annoyance to the merchants and the public is due to the skill with which the contractors have hung the sidewalks to the block itself, and carried up the same with the rise of the building. The block has been raised four feet eight inches, the required height, in five days, ending with Friday last, and the masons are now busy putting in the permanent supports. The entire work will occupy about four weeks.

An estimate from a reliable source makes the entire weight thus raised to be about 35,000 tons. So carefully has it been done, that not a pane of glass has been broken, nor a crack in masonry appeared. The internal order of the block has prevailed undisturbed.

The process of raising, as indicated above, is by the screw, at 6,000 of which, three inches in diameter and of three eighths thread, 600 men have been employed, each man in charge of from eight to ten screws. A complete system of signals was kept in operation, and by these the workmen passed, each through his series, giving each screw a quarter turn, then returning to repeat the same. Five days' labor saw the immense weight rise through four feet eight inches, to where it now stands on temporary supports, rapidly being replaced by permanent foundations. The work, as it stands, is worth going miles to see, and has drawn the admiration of thousands within the past week.

The bridges of Chicago are among the curiosities of the place. The numerous branches of the river require a large number of bridges. The river being navigable, and but little below the level of the streets, compels all of these to be made draw bridges. These are hung in the middle, and turn



South-west View of the Railroad Depot, Grain Houses, Chicago.

The Illinois Central Passenger, and the freight depot, etc., are seen in the central part. Sturges and Buckingham's grain houses standing on the lake shore, appear on the right; each of which will contain 750,000 bushels of grain; enough, it is estimated, to feed the entire population of the city for five years; 225,000 bushels can be received and stored in each of them in a single day.

on a pivot, the motive power being two men standing there with a cross-bar. The operation of turning a bridge, occupies about two minutes. While the process is going on, a closely packed row of vehicles, sometimes, accumulates of a quarter of a mile in length. Policemen are stationed at either end, to prevent persons from driving, jumping, or being pushed into the water.

The manufacturing establishments of Chicago are numerous, consisting of